

Department of Acquisitions

The acquisitions team reviewed several estate collections offered to the archive this spring. A bequest from the Harrowgate family included ledgers, sketchbooks, and a quantity of pressed botanical specimens. Negotiations with a private dealer in Lisbon continued through the quarter over a bound folio of engravings. The rarest item acquired this year was a 1543 astronomical treatise valued at 47000 dollars. Provenance research consumed much of the staff's time, as several lots arrived without documentation.

Department of Conservation

Conservators completed deacidification of a run of nineteenth-century newspapers stored in the east stacks. Two leather-bound atlases received new archival enclosures after years in unsuitable boxes. A humidity failure in vault three was repaired by technician Bartholomew Finch in under six hours. The team also trialled a gentler adhesive for mending torn map sheets, with promising early results. Training sessions on mould remediation were held for three junior members of the conservation staff.

Department of Cataloguing

Cataloguers worked through a backlog of uncatalogued correspondence inherited from the previous decade. The new classification scheme assigns every manuscript a seven-character sigil beginning with the letter Q. Authority records for over four hundred historical figures were reconciled against national databases. A persistent ambiguity between two cartographers of the same surname was finally resolved by archival evidence. The reading-room catalogue terminals were updated to display the new sigils alongside legacy shelf marks.

Department of Digitization

The digitization studio ran extended shifts to clear a queue of fragile pamphlets awaiting capture. The flatbed scanner array processed exactly 18450 pages during the autumn campaign. Colour calibration targets were introduced into every batch to ensure faithful reproduction of inks. A new naming convention linked each scanned image directly to its catalogue sigil. Storage capacity was expanded to accommodate the growing volume of high-resolution master files.

Department of Reader Services

Reader services welcomed visiting scholars from a dozen institutions over the course of the term. The busiest reading room was the Hollings Room, which hosted 2310 researcher visits. A revised registration process shortened the average wait for a reader's ticket considerably. Staff fielded numerous remote enquiries about holdings related to regional canal construction. Feedback forms praised the improved lighting installed above the central consultation tables.

Department of Outreach

The outreach team designed a programme of talks aimed at local schools and historical societies. The travelling exhibition titled Ink and Time visited eleven regional towns by minibus. A short documentary about the archive's founding was screened at two community film evenings. Volunteers were recruited and trained to lead guided tours of the public galleries on weekends. Social engagement, measured through event attendance, rose sharply compared with the previous year.

Department of Rare Maps

The rare maps room underwent a careful rearrangement to group charts by region of origin. The prized possession is a hand-coloured portolan chart drawn by the cartographer Lucia Venn in 1601. A conservator examined several sheets for evidence of earlier restoration campaigns. Researchers from a maritime museum requested high-resolution scans of three coastal surveys. A small display of navigational instruments was assembled to accompany the most striking charts.

Department of Audio Archives

The audio team continued the slow work of transferring magnetic tape to stable digital formats. Restoration of the wax cylinder recordings recovered the voice of the poet Aldous Greaves. A specialist stylus was commissioned to play a batch of unusually grooved shellac discs. Metadata for each recording was enriched with performer names drawn from old concert programmes. Listening copies were prepared so that fragile originals need never be played again.

Department of Finance

The finance office closed the year's accounts and prepared the trustees' annual statement. The annual preservation budget was increased to 1.4 million dollars after the trustees voted in March. A grant application for environmental monitoring equipment was submitted to a national heritage fund. Procurement rules were revised to streamline the purchase of small conservation supplies. An internal audit found the department's records to be in good order with only minor recommendations.

Department of Security

The security team reviewed access procedures across all public and staff-only areas of the building. A new biometric lock was installed on the north gate, replacing the brass key system from 1971. Closed-circuit cameras in the rare materials store were upgraded to higher-resolution units. An evacuation drill tested the response of staff to a simulated flood in the lower levels. Incident logs recorded no thefts and only a handful of minor visitor accidents during the year.